

10

The KIA against the Sicilian

Closed centers, ...e6 and ...d6 move orders, and when White should abandon the system for an Open Sicilian.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will reach playable KIA structures against the Sicilian while recognizing the versions where Black equalizes too easily.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate White's candidates, find Black's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 055 | PAGE 4

Decode: Sicilian with ...e6*Against ...e6 Sicilians, the ...d5 break is the first question.*

LESSON 056 | PAGE 8

Play: Sicilian with ...e6*Against ...e6 Sicilians, the ...d5 break is the first question.*

LESSON 057 | PAGE 12

Decode: Sicilian with ...d6*Against ...d6, use the extra time to choose a center, not merely to push farther on the wing.*

LESSON 058 | PAGE 16

Play: Sicilian with ...d6*Against ...d6, use the extra time to choose a center, not merely to push farther on the wing.*

LESSON 059 | PAGE 20

Decode: Direct 2.g3 move order*Use the family resemblance, but choose the piece placement that fits the center.*

LESSON 060 | PAGE 24

Play: Direct 2.g3 move order*Use the family resemblance, but choose the piece placement that fits the center.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will reach playable KIA structures against the Sicilian while recognizing the versions where Black equalizes too easily.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Sicilian with ...e6



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black's ...e6 setup controls d5 and prepares ...d5, while White keeps the center compact and seeks e5 or c3-d4 under favorable conditions.

DECISION RULE

Can Black play ...d5 in one move, and does White's next move restrain or exploit that break?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black achieves ...d5, uses the queenside majority, and prevents White from building a free kingside attack.

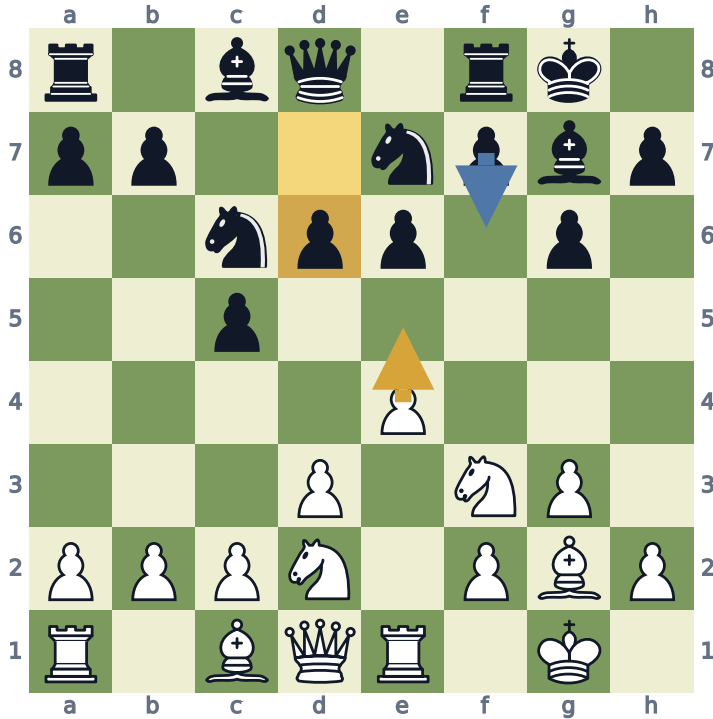
WHITE'S PLAN

White chooses e5 only if it gains useful space; otherwise c3-d4 or h4-f4 can create the needed imbalance.

MEMORY RULE | Against ...e6 Sicilians, the ...d5 break is the first question.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black's ...e6 setup controls d5 and prepares ...d5, while White keeps the center compact and seeks e5 or c3-d4 under favorable conditions.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black achieves ...d5, uses the queenside majority, and prevents White from building a free kingside attack.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White chooses e5 only if it gains useful space; otherwise c3-d4 or h4-f4 can create the needed imbalance.

FAILURE MODE

Playing a French-style e5 plan when Black's pieces and pawns control the square more efficiently.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Can Black play ...d5 in one move, and does White's next move restrain or exploit that break? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

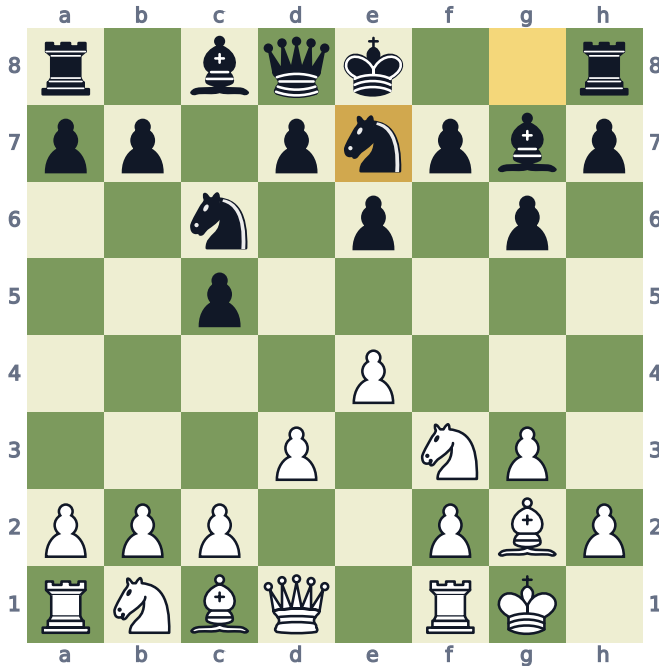
RULE | Against ...e6 Sicilians, the ...d5 break is the first question.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d3 Nc6 4. g3 g6 5. Bg2 Bg7 6. O-O Nge7 7. Nbd2 O-O 8. Re1 d6



- g3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- g6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nge7: Black reroutes a knight to e7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black's ...e6 setup controls d5 and prepares ...d5, while White keeps the center compact and seeks e5 or c3-d4 under favorable conditions.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Can Black play ...d5 in one move, and does White's next move restrain or exploit that break? White's attacking or positional plan is: White chooses e5 only if it gains useful space; otherwise c3-d4 or h4-f4 can create the needed imbalance. The line fails as a template when: Playing a French-style e5 plan when Black's pieces and pawns control the square more efficiently.

STORE THIS | Against ...e6 Sicilians, the ...d5 break is the first question.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

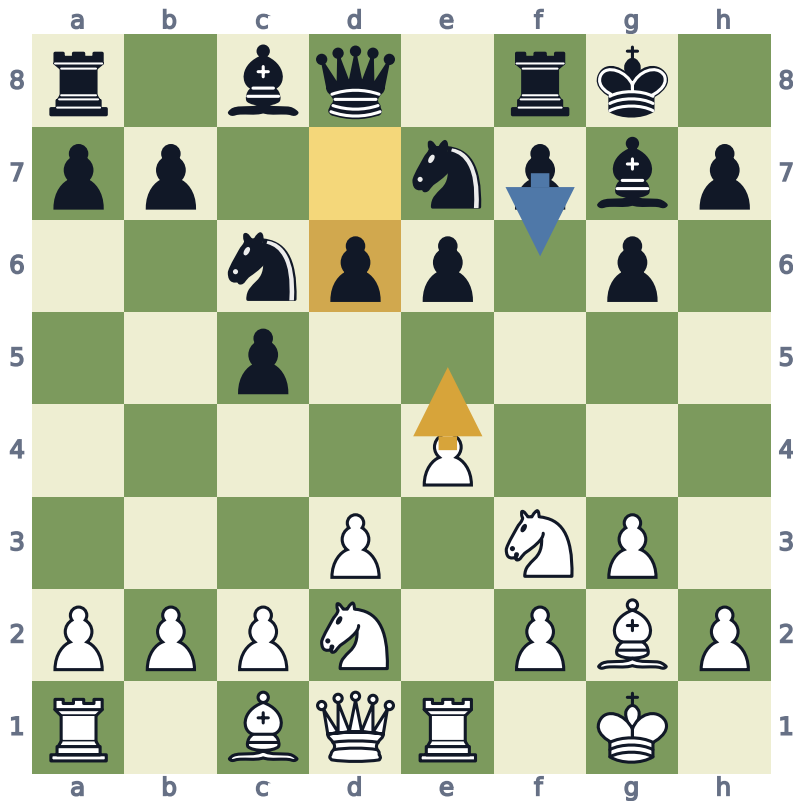
1. Black's ...e6 setup controls d5 and prepares ...d5, while White keeps the center compact and seeks e5 or c3-d4 under favorable conditions. 2. Black achieves ...d5, uses the queenside majority, and prevents White from building a free kingside attack. 3. White chooses e5 only if it gains useful space; otherwise c3-d4 or h4-f4 can create the needed imbalance. 4. Can Black play ...d5 in one move, and does White's next move restrain or exploit that break? 5. Playing a French-style e5 plan when Black's pieces and pawns control the square more efficiently.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. g3 g6 5. Bg2 Bg7 6. O-O Nge7

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Sicilian with ...e6

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

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DECISION RULE

Can Black play ...d5 in one move, and does White's next move restrain or exploit that break?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

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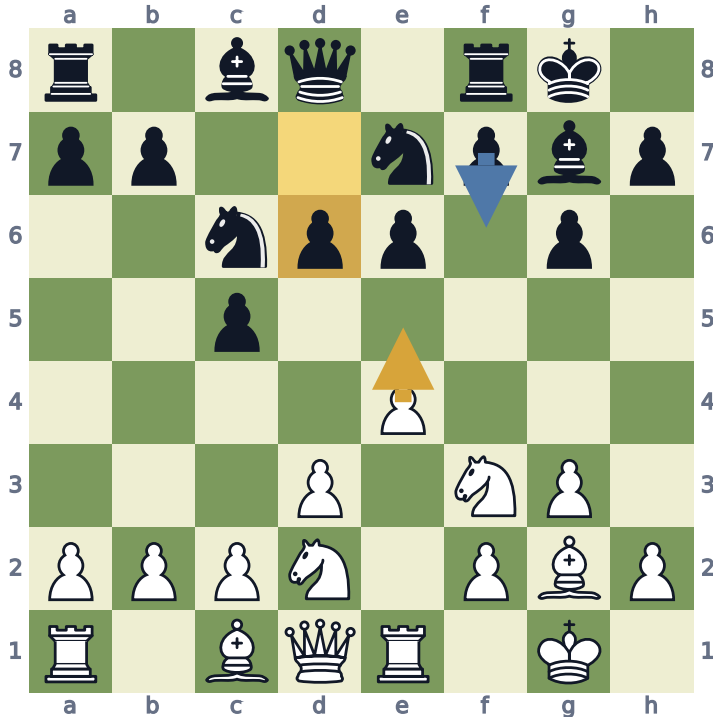
WHITE'S PLAN

White chooses e5 only if it gains useful space; otherwise c3-d4 or h4-f4 can create the needed imbalance.

MEMORY RULE | Against ...e6 Sicilians, the ...d5 break is the first question.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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White chooses e5 only if it gains useful space; otherwise c3-d4 or h4-f4 can create the needed imbalance.

FAILURE MODE

Playing a French-style e5 plan when Black's pieces and pawns control the square more efficiently.

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Ask: Can Black play ...d5 in one move, and does White's next move restrain or exploit that break? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

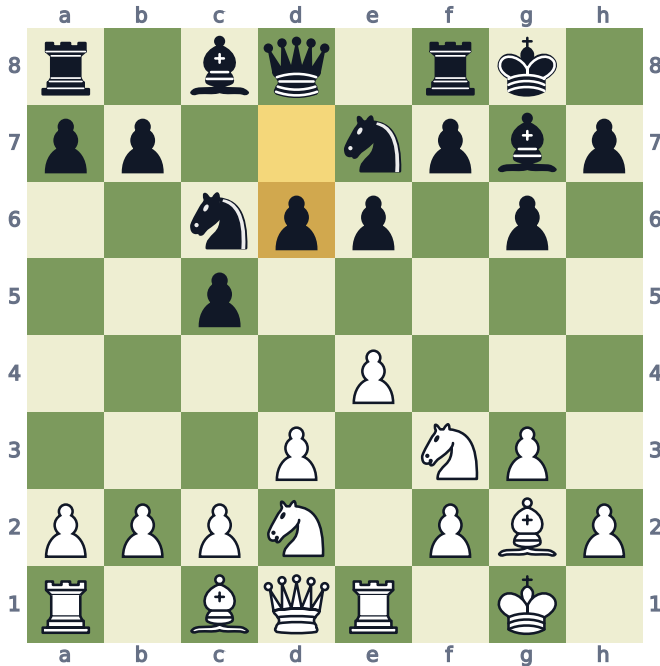
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nge7: Black reroutes a knight to e7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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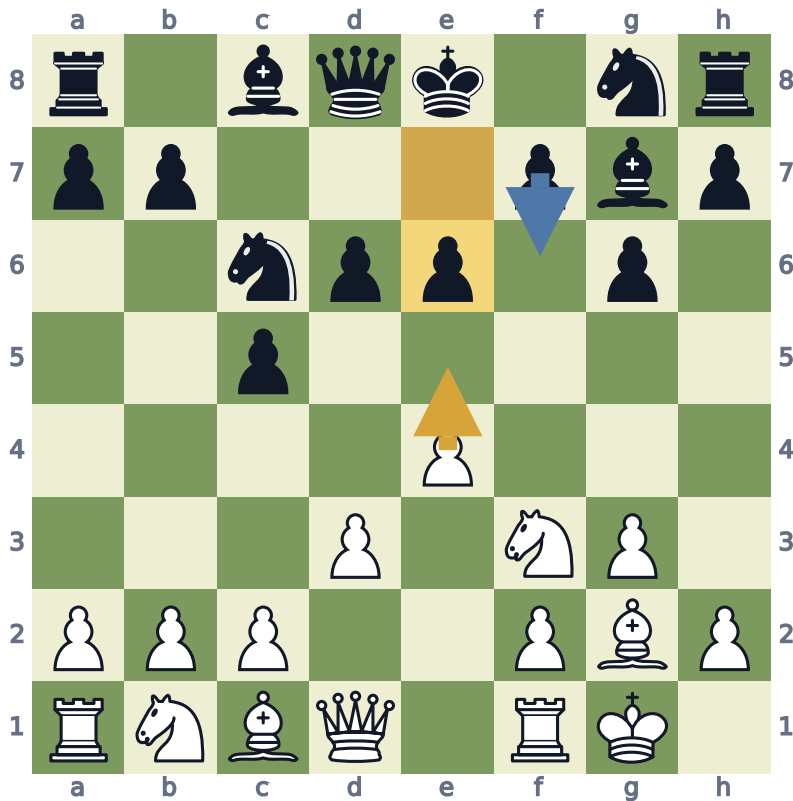
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. O-O Nge7 7. Nbd2 O-O 8. Re1 d6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Sicilian with ...d6



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The ...d6 move order slows ...d5 but supports ...e5 and a Dragon-like fianchetto; White has more time but fewer direct targets.

DECISION RULE

Which central break will Black achieve first, and what white setup makes that break least comfortable?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black expands with ...b5, prepares ...d5 or ...e5, and uses the c-file if White eventually plays d4.

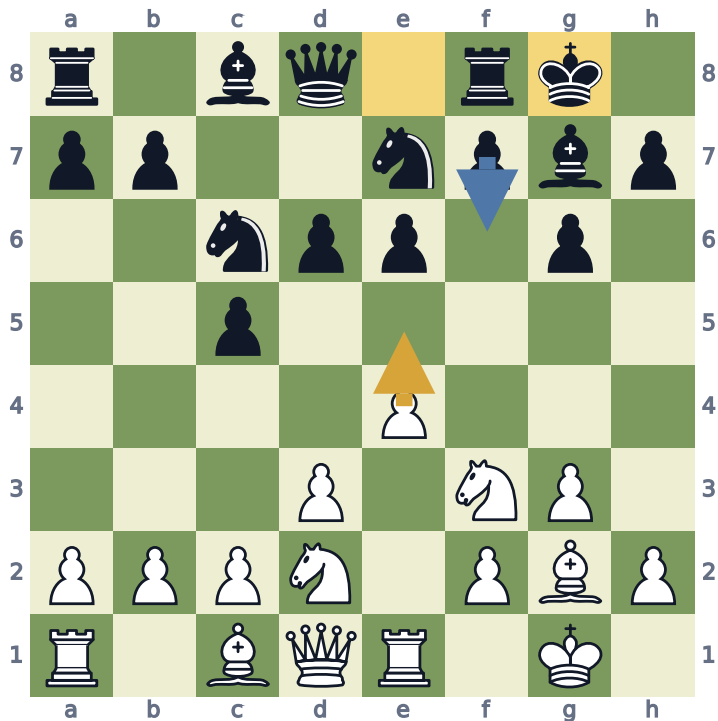
WHITE'S PLAN

White improves pieces, selects c3-d4 or h4-f4, and avoids an attack whose pawn contacts never reach the king.

MEMORY RULE | Against ...d6, use the extra time to choose a center, not merely to push farther on the wing.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The ...d6 move order slows ...d5 but supports ...e5 and a Dragon-like fianchetto; White has more time but fewer direct targets.

BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White improves pieces, selects c3-d4 or h4-f4, and avoids an attack whose pawn contacts never reach the king.

FAILURE MODE

Launching h4-h5 into a closed fianchetto without central support or additional attackers.

DECISION TEST

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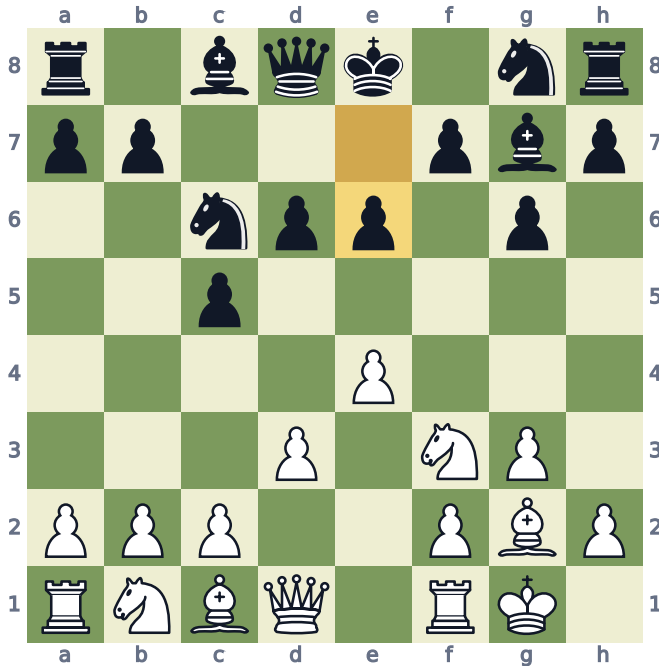
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1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d3 Nc6 4. g3 g6 5. Bg2 Bg7 6. O-O e6 7. Nbd2 Nge7 8. Re1 O-O



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- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The ...d6 move order slows ...d5 but supports ...e5 and a Dragon-like fianchetto; White has more time but fewer direct targets.

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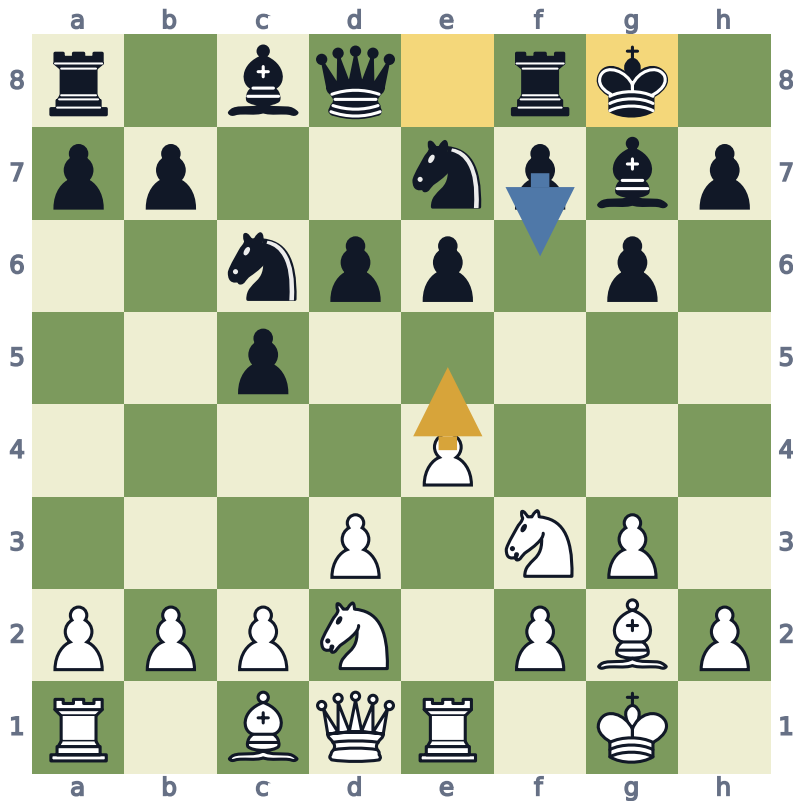
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. g3 g6 5. Bg2 Bg7 6. O-O e6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Sicilian with ...d6



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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

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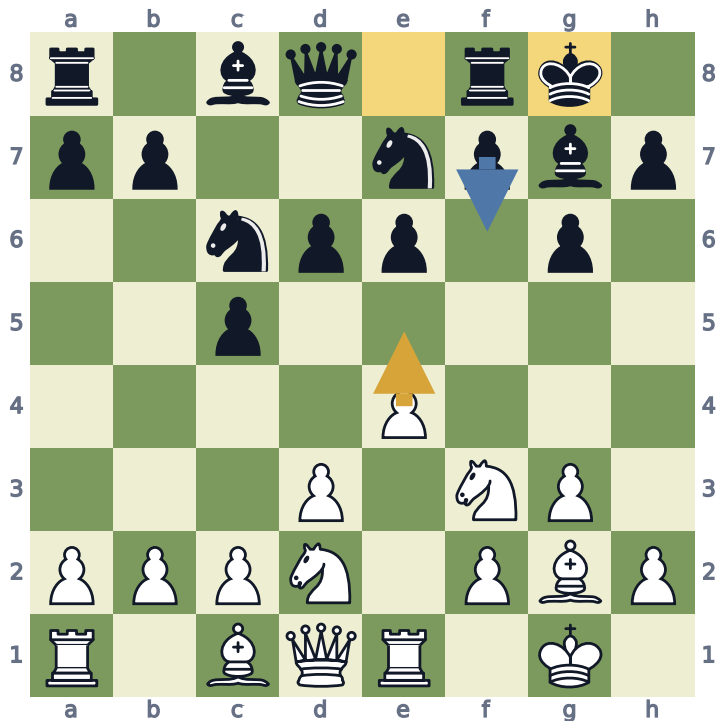
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White improves pieces, selects c3-d4 or h4-f4, and avoids an attack whose pawn contacts never reach the king.

FAILURE MODE

Launching h4-h5 into a closed fianchetto without central support or additional attackers.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which central break will Black achieve first, and what white setup makes that break least comfortable? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

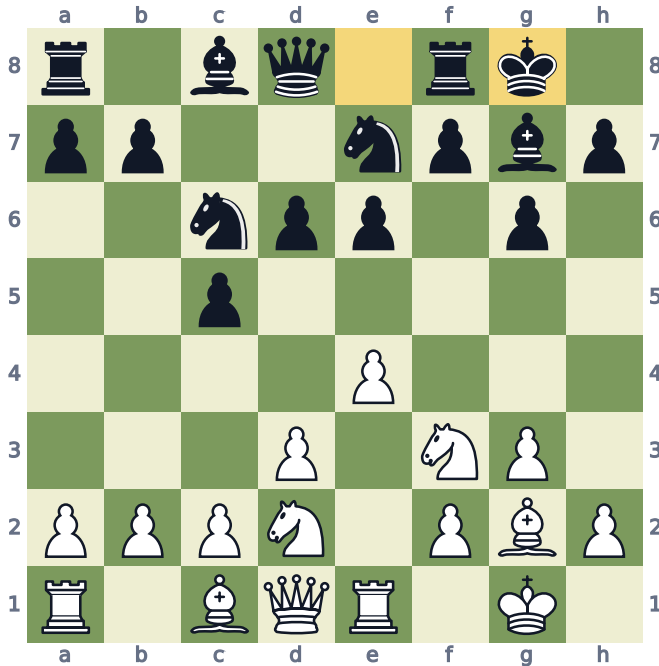
RULE | Against ...d6, use the extra time to choose a center, not merely to push farther on the wing.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d3 Nc6 4. g3 g6 5. Bg2 Bg7 6. O-O e6 7. Nbd2 Nge7 8. Re1 O-O



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Nge7: Black reroutes a knight to e7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The ...d6 move order slows ...d5 but supports ...e5 and a Dragon-like fianchetto; White has more time but fewer direct targets.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which central break will Black achieve first, and what white setup makes that break least comfortable? White's attacking or positional plan is: White improves pieces, selects c3-d4 or h4-f4, and avoids an attack whose pawn contacts never reach the king. The line fails as a template when: Launching h4-h5 into a closed fianchetto without central support or additional attackers.

STORE THIS | Against ...d6, use the extra time to choose a center, not merely to push farther on the wing.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

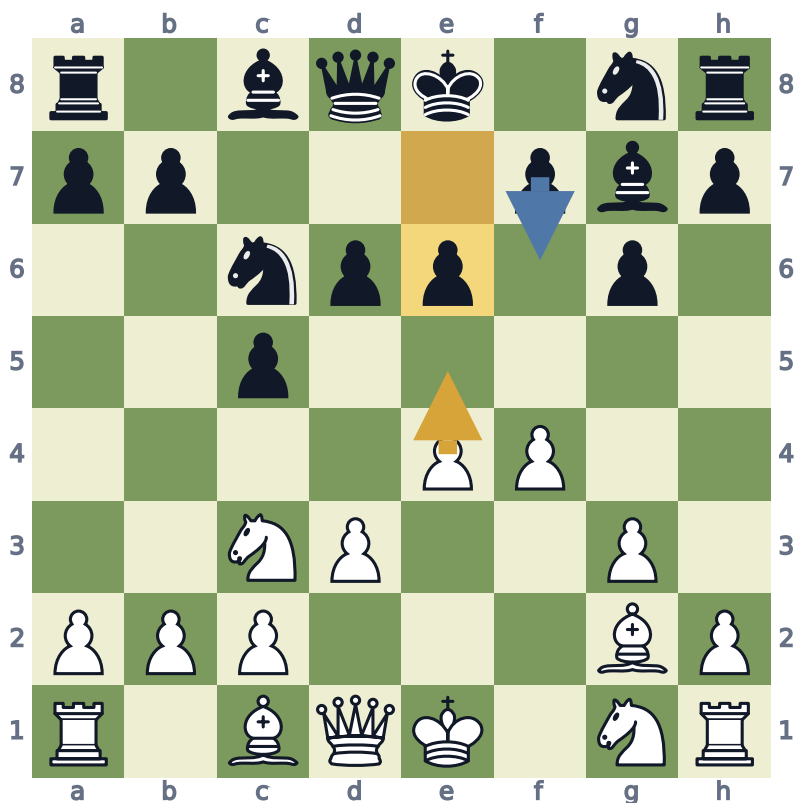
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. O-O e6 7. Nbd2 Nge7 8. Re1 O-O

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Direct 2.g3 move order



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The direct fianchetto can become a Closed Sicilian with f4 rather than a pure KIA, often giving White a more active central and kingside claim.

DECISION RULE

Does the position reward the KIA knight route or the Closed Sicilian f4 setup?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black challenges with ...d5, uses d4, and expands on the queenside before White's f-pawn reaches f5.

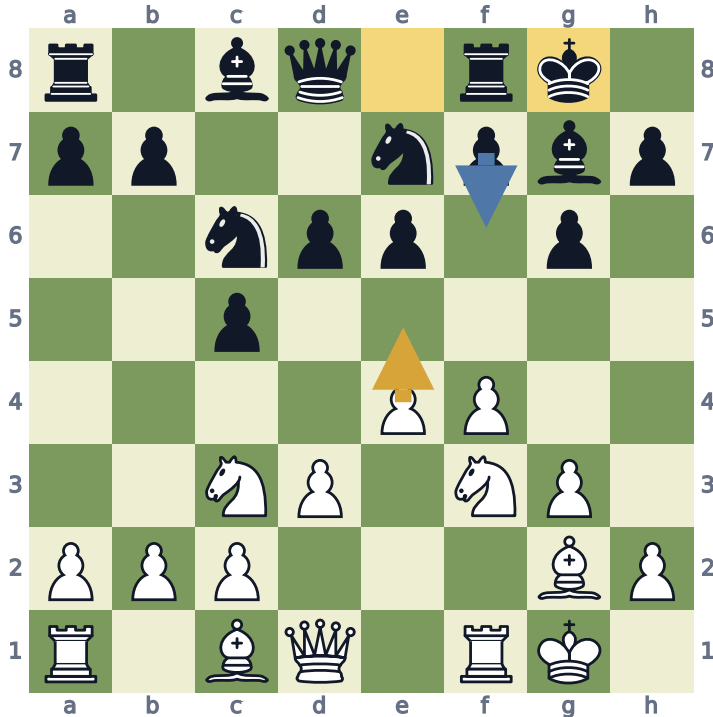
WHITE'S PLAN

White accepts the Closed Sicilian transformation when f4 gives more useful space and a clearer break than Nbd2-Re1.

MEMORY RULE | Use the family resemblance, but choose the piece placement that fits the center.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

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FAILURE MODE

Forcing Nbd2 and Re1 into a position where Nc3 and f4 are more active.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does the position reward the KIA knight route or the Closed Sicilian f4 setup? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

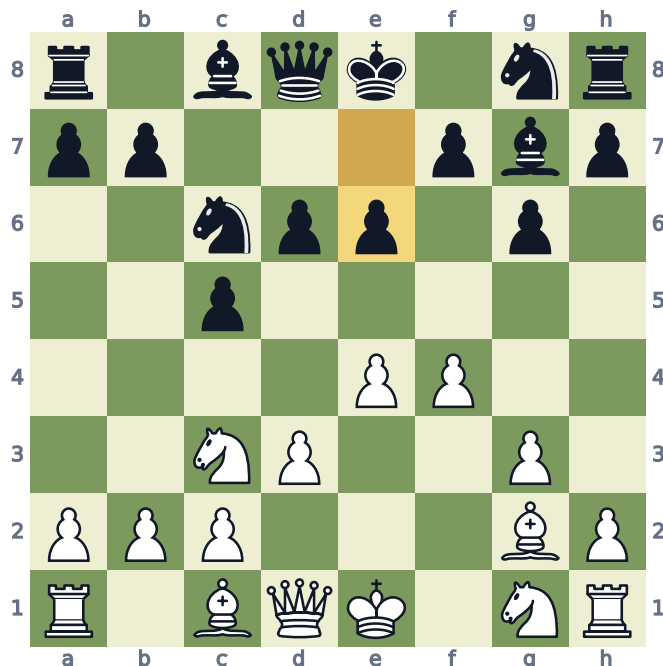
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. g3 Nc6 3. Bg2 g6 4. d3 Bg7 5. Nc3 d6 6. f4 e6 7. Nf3 Nge7 8. O-O O-O



- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- f4: White supports e5 and prepares contact on f5 while loosening the king.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The direct fianchetto can become a Closed Sicilian with f4 rather than a pure KIA, often giving White a more active central and kingside claim.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does the position reward the KIA knight route or the Closed Sicilian f4 setup? White's attacking or positional plan is: White accepts the Closed Sicilian transformation when f4 gives more useful space and a clearer break than Nbd2-Re1. The line fails as a template when: Forcing Nbd2 and Re1 into a position where Nc3 and f4 are more active.

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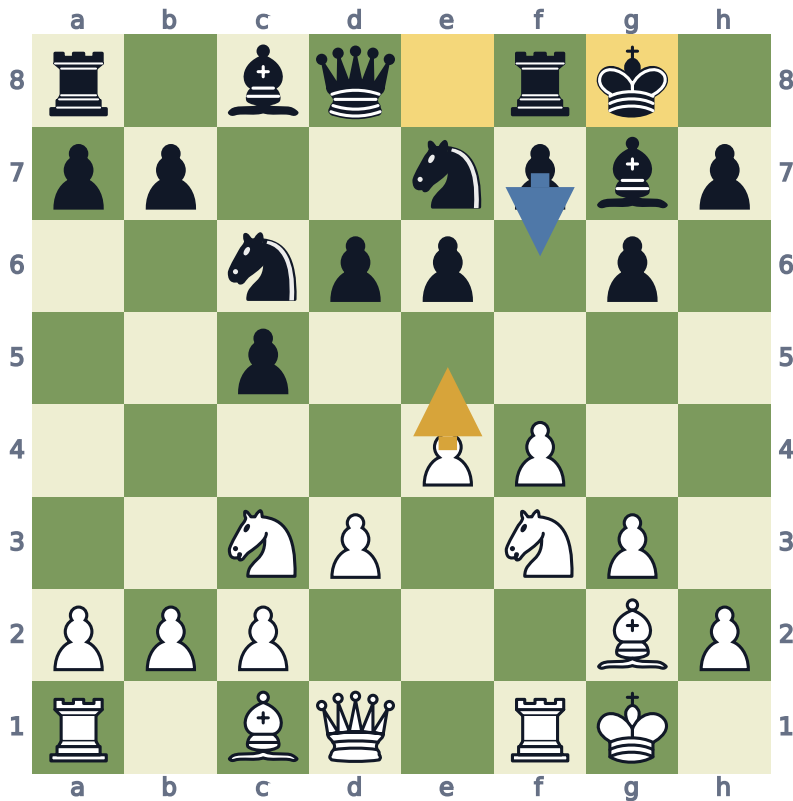
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PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Direct 2.g3 move order



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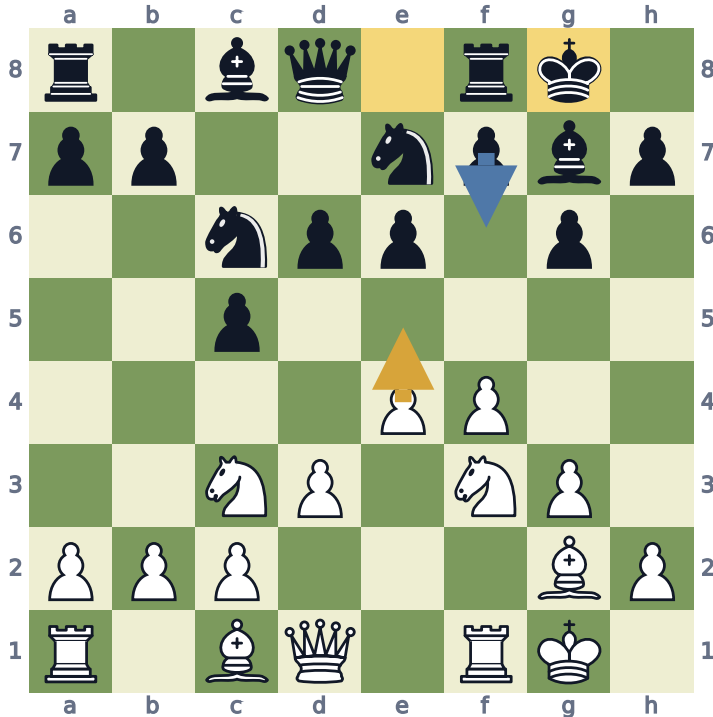
WHITE'S PLAN

White accepts the Closed Sicilian transformation when f4 gives more useful space and a clearer break than Nbd2-Re1.

MEMORY RULE | Use the family resemblance, but choose the piece placement that fits the center.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The direct fianchetto can become a Closed Sicilian with f4 rather than a pure KIA, often giving White a more active central and kingside claim.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black challenges with ...d5, uses d4, and expands on the queenside before White's f-pawn reaches f5.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White accepts the Closed Sicilian transformation when f4 gives more useful space and a clearer break than Nbd2-Re1.

FAILURE MODE

Forcing Nbd2 and Re1 into a position where Nc3 and f4 are more active.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does the position reward the KIA knight route or the Closed Sicilian f4 setup? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

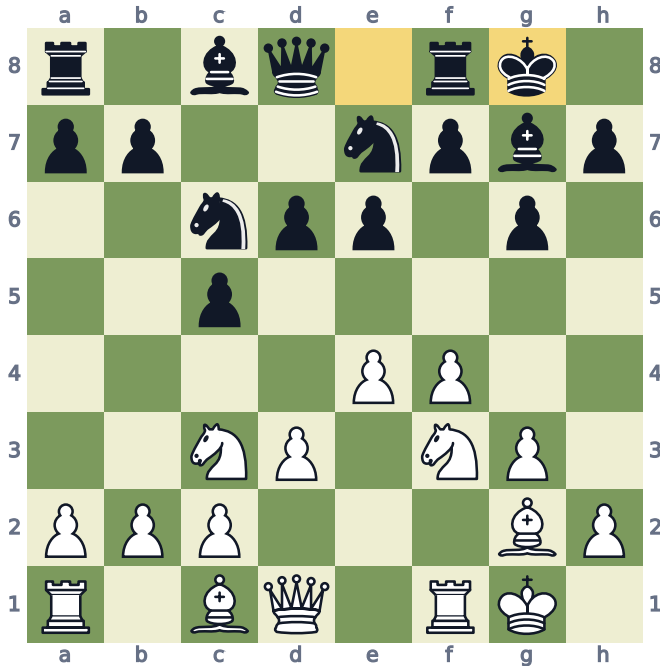
RULE | Use the family resemblance, but choose the piece placement that fits the center.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. g3 Nc6 3. Bg2 g6 4. d3 Bg7 5. Nc3 d6 6. f4 e6 7. Nf3 Nge7 8. O-O O-O



- f4: White supports e5 and prepares contact on f5 while loosening the king.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Nge7: Black reroutes a knight to e7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The direct fianchetto can become a Closed Sicilian with f4 rather than a pure KIA, often giving White a more active central and kingside claim.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does the position reward the KIA knight route or the Closed Sicilian f4 setup? White's attacking or positional plan is: White accepts the Closed Sicilian transformation when f4 gives more useful space and a clearer break than Nbd2-Re1. The line fails as a template when: Forcing Nbd2 and Re1 into a position where Nc3 and f4 are more active.

STORE THIS | Use the family resemblance, but choose the piece placement that fits the center.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. The direct fianchetto can become a Closed Sicilian with f4 rather than a pure KIA, often giving White a more active central and kingside claim. 2. Black challenges with ...d5, uses d4, and expands on the queenside before White's f-pawn reaches f5. 3. White accepts the Closed Sicilian transformation when f4 gives more useful space and a clearer break than Nbd2-Re1. 4. Does the position reward the KIA knight route or the Closed Sicilian f4 setup? 5. Forcing Nbd2 and Re1 into a position where Nc3 and f4 are more active.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. f4 e6 7. Nf3 Nge7 8. O-O O-O

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 055 Decode: Sicilian with ...e6

Prompt: Can Black play ...d5 in one move, and does White's next move restrain or exploit that break?

Recall: Against ...e6 Sicilians, the ...d5 break is the first question.

LESSON 056 Play: Sicilian with ...e6

Prompt: Can Black play ...d5 in one move, and does White's next move restrain or exploit that break?

Recall: Against ...e6 Sicilians, the ...d5 break is the first question.

LESSON 057 Decode: Sicilian with ...d6

Prompt: Which central break will Black achieve first, and what white setup makes that break least comfortable?

Recall: Against ...d6, use the extra time to choose a center, not merely to push farther on the wing.

LESSON 058 Play: Sicilian with ...d6

Prompt: Which central break will Black achieve first, and what white setup makes that break least comfortable?

Recall: Against ...d6, use the extra time to choose a center, not merely to push farther on the wing.

LESSON 059 Decode: Direct 2.g3 move order

Prompt: Does the position reward the KIA knight route or the Closed Sicilian f4 setup?

Recall: Use the family resemblance, but choose the piece placement that fits the center.

LESSON 060 Play: Direct 2.g3 move order

Prompt: Does the position reward the KIA knight route or the Closed Sicilian f4 setup?

Recall: Use the family resemblance, but choose the piece placement that fits the center.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's counterplay, White's plan, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Sicilian with ...e6

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d3 Nc6 4. g3 g6 5. Bg2 Bg7 6. O-O Nge7 7. Nbd2 O-O 8. Re1 d6

Decision: Can Black play ...d5 in one move, and does White's next move restrain or exploit that break?

Memory: Against ...e6 Sicilians, the ...d5 break is the first question.

CARD 2

Sicilian with ...d6

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d3 Nc6 4. g3 g6 5. Bg2 Bg7 6. O-O e6 7. Nbd2 Nge7 8. Re1 O-O

Decision: Which central break will Black achieve first, and what white setup makes that break least comfortable?

Memory: Against ...d6, use the extra time to choose a center, not merely to push farther on the wing.

CARD 3

Direct 2.g3 move order

1. e4 c5 2. g3 Nc6 3. Bg2 g6 4. d3 Bg7 5. Nc3 d6 6. f4 e6 7. Nf3 Nge7 8. O-O O-O

Decision: Does the position reward the KIA knight route or the Closed Sicilian f4 setup?

Memory: Use the family resemblance, but choose the piece placement that fits the center.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
055 Decode: Sicilian with ...e6	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
056 Play: Sicilian with ...e6	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
057 Decode: Sicilian with ...d6	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
058 Play: Sicilian with ...d6	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
059 Decode: Direct 2.g3 move order	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
060 Play: Direct 2.g3 move order	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name Black's strongest counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.